of people in the three belligerent countries. The Cuban side of the story, long unavailable, has become known in recent decades with the publication and eventual translation into English of works by Cuban historians.[5]

But no matter how many academic and popular studies have been written and published in recent years and decades about the Cuban missile crisis, the dominant narrative remains the same: John Kennedy refused to budge and, thanks to the decision-making process involving his closest advisers, managed to make the right assumptions and draw the right conclusions about Soviet intentions and capabilities, thereby resolving the crisis. I challenge that established narrative by taking a road toward the reconstruction and understanding of the Cuban missile crisis rarely traveled before. Instead of identifying moments in the crisis when key figures and rank-and-file participants got things right and determining how they reached those correct decisions, I consider the myriad situations in which they got things wrong.

John Kennedy, highly alert to the possibility of starting a war by misreading the adversary, was particularly impressed by Barbara Tuchman's Pulitzer Prize–winning history of the "accidental" outbreak of World War I, *The Guns of August*, published in the spring of 1962. He not only gave copies to close allies but also had the book sent to American military commanders throughout the world. But the story of the crisis, as I see it, might be well summarized by the title of another award-winning book by Tuchman, *The March of Folly*. As I show in this book, both Kennedy and Khrushchev marched from one mistake to another. They were caused by a variety of factors, from ideological hubris and overriding political agendas to misreading the other side's geostrategic objectives and intentions, poor judgment often due to the lack of good intelligence, and cultural misunderstandings.[6]

Kennedy found it difficult to understand Khrushchev's motives and was consumed with worry about a nuclear crisis over Berlin. He proposed a strike against the Soviet missiles in Cuba without knowing either the number of Soviet troops on the island or their nuclear capabilities. Khrushchev, never expecting such a determined response from Kennedy, panicked at first and then had difficulty communicating his desire to resolve the crisis as soon as possible. He lost the initiative and, ultimately, control